We were ready to rub shoulders with French scientists and engineers, and now we realised a problem: the French spoke little or no English, and none of our men knew French. It was time for school. The VSSC conference hall in Trivandrum turned into a French tutorial for two months. But, at the end of it, our men still couldn't make out a croissant from a cake. The tutorial was a disaster. We decided to get French lessons in the best place—France. The French, too, realised the futility of working together without sharing a language. SEP was magnanimous to spend 25,000 Francs to educate our men. Berlitz School of Language did in twenty-one days what our *desi* French tutor could not for two months. At the end of the three-week course, our men could hold a civil conversation with our French brothers.

Talking of civility, it also took a session by Seshan and Brahm Prakash to sensitise the team on French manners. Many of our scientists were travelling out of the country for the first time. Seshan spoke about how to behave in a foreign land.

Next came the question of medical cover for the team. ISRO was not yet a government department—it was an autonomous institution reporting directly to the prime minister. It had its positives and negatives. While the autonomy and the direct access to the PMO helped the organisation surpass red tape to ensure speedy clearance of projects, the employees did not enjoy benefits including medical cover that government employees were entitled to.

Seshan, the administrative head, worked out a basic medical cover, but that was too insufficient to deal with any serious situation as healthcare was prohibitively expensive in France. To minimise damage, we advised the team members to get basic medical checks done in India before flying. Dental problems need to be fixed, they were told, and do not take pregnant wives to France.

The rest of the formalities were a breeze, with the government fast-tracking our visas and other documents. I was given the powers equivalent to that of the head of the department of the government. I was so confident of the team that I readily agreed to SEP's condition that if anyone is not up